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WWDC21 Spotlight – Swift Student Challenge Winner

Sabesh Bharathi was one of the 350 Winners of the Switch Student Challenge 2021

Mithun Mohandas | mithun@digit.in

Apple's coding competition for youngsters had a surprising number of winners from India this year. We spoke to Sabesh Bharathi, one of the winners from SSN College of Engineering, Chennai to learn about his experience of being part of Switch Student Challenge 2021.

How did you come across Swift Student Challenge and what was your winning entry?

Sabesh: I heard about the challenge in 2019 from my cousin brother and it was a bit too late for me to enter. It had already commenced and I didn't have any knowledge on the programming language or the ecosystem back then. So I delved deeper into it and started learning Swift. I applied for Swift Student Challenge in 2020 but I didn't make it through because I was still learning the language. This time around, I felt confident enough to attempt again and sure enough, it made it through.

My submission's name is 'Ruby's Dilemma' and the theme was Climate Crisis which is a really pressing issue at the moment. What prompted me to pick this theme was that Apple gives you the freedom to pick topics and as a person who loves nature, I felt the need for awareness to be spread among the general public. That's why I picked this topic.



Sabesh Bharathia

How would you gauge the difficulty of the competition?

Sabesh: There is a very drastic difference between Swift Student Challenge compared to other coding competitions around the world because this is exclusively for students and there are numerous winners under the age of 13 and 14. I believe Apple here is seeking out creativity and originality more than the technical aspect of it. Most of the technical aspects of Playgrounds are really easy for even a student to understand. Every single framework can be easily integrated into Playgrounds. Let's say you want to do Machine Learning, then Apple has this framework called Create ML and Core ML, I sat down at my laptop and I was able to create a machine learning model in under five minutes. It was really simple, I had to drag and drop a couple of images and write two lines of code and it was done. I built a simple ML model that was able to distinguish between dogs and cats. The difficult part is to come up with something original to present your solution.

Have you tried Scratch or Grasshopper which are similar to Playgrounds?

Sabesh: I actually haven't tried

those platforms so I'm not one to speak.

Scratch is quite basic. It uses a lot of drag and drop elements which you can easily interconnect to build your program.

I feel like I've tried this when I was younger. Since Apple is promoting Playgrounds, it has enjoyed a vast response around the world, especially the U.S. From

what I remember, the experience of using Scratch was very similar but the experience on Playgrounds is unparalleled. Every single resource that you need is in the Playgrounds app. You can develop apps and even publish it right from the Playgrounds app. I feel like it's all coming together and slowly gaining recognition.

You mentioned that you've tried several similar platforms when you were younger. So when did you start tinkering with coding for the first time?

Sabesh: Contrary to most folks, I do remember the first language that I learnt. It was Qbasic and it was taught to me in 5th Grade back in school. I really loved the logic that went into programming. Qbasic really made me think and at most I'd have made two fully-fledged programs in it. One of them was a "Prophecy Predictor", so if you asked it a question it would randomly tell you yes or no. Over the years, I switched to more complex languages such as C and C++. And this is where I believe that a change needs to happen. Swift is a good language for starters whereas C++ is not. So if a child wants to learn coding then Swift is a better language.